Jaffna enjoyed support from certain political parties. The Tamil Nadu Forensics Lab asked why an agency (read the CBI) from New Delhi was coming to take all the credit. Even the CBI did not take the findings of the lab—that the assassination was the work of a human bomb—at face value and sent the results to the Centre for Cellular and Molecular Biology in Hyderabad for verification. So tissues collected from the dismembered female body with remains of the green-and-orange salwar kameez, the vest bomb and the blast site were sent again to Hyderabad. The scientists upheld the findings and conclusions arrived at by Chandrasekharan. However, Datta did not agree with that observation. According to him, the CBI always got evidence collected by other agencies verified.

Meanwhile, Shekhar Gupta learnt that, based on a video film shot minutes before the blast, the two women who were seen in the first picture taken by Haribabu had been identified as S. Kokila and Latha Kannan, standing with the suspected human bomb. Latha Kannan was a Congress worker and must have had secured permission to greet Rajiv in the red carpet area through party seniors. The million-dollar question was how the suspected assassin knew Kannan. Did she gain access to the red carpet area, which was meant only for VVIP security, with Kannan's help? Obviously, it was too early to get that answer, even for the investigators. Therefore, speculations could not be stopped. Security across Tamil Nadu was beefed up with the deployment of paramilitary units and army columns in areas that had Sri Lankan refugee camps.

Inderjit Badhwar, wearing a tracksuit, walked into the newsroom. 'That's a hell of a story from Shekhar and team,' he told everyone and then turned to Anirudhya. 'Sonny, it's your turn now. Go to Suri and give him your travel plans for Madras.'

Two things struck Anirudhya. First, that he was finally going to the scene of crime for his story, and, second, that the managing editor had come into office wearing a tracksuit. Was he coming straight from a jog? Well, no